Supreme Court Says Border Wall Work Can Go On in West Texas

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On Monday, the U.S. Supreme Court said work on border walls in west Texas can keep going while a court case about the plans is still being decided. The decision opens the way for hundreds of miles of walls and security work in the Big Bend area, including land inside Big Bend National Park.

The court's five-page decision was **unsigned**, which means no judge signed it as the writer. It said the judge in El Paso who had stopped the work did not have the power to do so. Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson was the only judge who disagreed.

The judge's stop had paused work on 30-foot-tall steel walls, **patrol** roads, and camera systems that watch the border. The court said **federal** law lets the head of **Homeland Security**, Markwayne Mullin, set aside laws that protect nature so building can move faster.

The case was brought by the Center for **Biological Diversity**, a group that works to protect nature. Critics say the wall is not needed there, because the rough land and hot desert already make crossings rare.

Word Treasure

unsigned -- An unsigned decision is one that no judge signed as the writer.

patrol -- Patrol means watching over an area to keep it safe.

federal -- Federal means having to do with the national government of the United States.

Homeland Security -- Homeland Security is the part of the government that works to keep the country safe.

Biological Diversity -- Biological diversity means the many different kinds of living things in nature.

Background you need

The Supreme Court is the highest court in the United States, and it decides what the law means when people disagree.

A national park is a large area of land that is protected so its nature can stay wild.

In this case, the court had to decide whether building work could go on while a court case about it was still being decided.

Break it down

WHO: The U.S. Supreme Court, Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson, the head of Homeland Security Markwayne Mullin, and the Center for Biological Diversity

WHAT: The court said border wall work in west Texas can keep going while the court case about it is still being decided

WHERE: The Big Bend area of west Texas, including land inside Big Bend National Park

WHY: Federal law lets the head of Homeland Security set aside laws that protect nature so building can move faster

Why it matters

It matters because decisions about walls and wild land can change the places where animals live and where families visit nature.

Test what you remember

1. What did the Supreme Court say about the border wall work in west Texas?

- (A) It can only happen inside Big Bend National Park
- (B) It must stop forever
- (C) It must wait until a new law is passed
- (D) It can keep going while the court case is still being decided

2. Who was the only judge who disagreed?

- (A) The head of the Center for Biological Diversity
- (B) Markwayne Mullin
- (C) Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson
- (D) The judge in El Paso

3. What had the judge's stop paused?

- (A) Work on roads in El Paso
- (B) Building homes in west Texas
- (C) All visits to Big Bend National Park
- (D) 30-foot-tall steel walls, patrol roads, and camera systems

4. What does the court say federal law lets the head of Homeland Security do?

- (A) Set aside laws that protect nature so building can move faster
- (B) Close Big Bend National Park
- (C) Choose the judges for the case
- (D) Stop all crossings in the desert

5. Who brought the case?

- (A) The National Park Service
- (B) The Center for Biological Diversity
- (C) Critics of the wall
- (D) The judge in El Paso

6. Why do critics say the wall is not needed there?

- (A) The desert is too cold
- (B) The rough land and hot desert already make crossings rare
- (C) There are no roads in the area
- (D) The wall would be too short

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The Supreme Court: It said the work can keep going while the case is still being decided, because the judge in El Paso did not have the power to stop it.

2. The Center for Biological Diversity: The group works to protect nature and brought the case against the wall plans.

3. Critics of the wall: They say the wall is not needed there because the rough land and hot desert already make crossings rare.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):